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DXB among top-5 global low-cost carrier hubs

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai International Airport (DXB) has emerged as the world's 5th most connected low-cost carrier hub and leads the Middle East region, according to the latest OAG Megahubs 2025 report released yesterday.

The aviation connectivity study by OAG — a UK-based global travel data provider — shows Dubai “has the highest volume of potential LCC connections” in its category, with budget airline flydubai operating 28 per cent of flights and driving a 4 per cent year-on-year increase in low-cost connections.

DXB also secured 15th position in the world's most connected airports ranking.

\$92b to economy

According to the International Air Transport Association (IATA), the UAE's air transport sector contributes more than \$92 billion annually to the national economy, directly and indirectly accounting for roughly 18 per cent of GDP.

Direct employment within airlines, airport operators, air navigation service providers, and aerospace manufacturers totals approximately 206,800, generating \$26.6 billion, which is approximately 5.3 per cent of GDP.

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‘Dubai’s team’ to make city world’s best

DUBAI TO CUT COST OF EDUCATION, HOUSING, TOP OFFICIALS SAY

DUBAI
Gulf News Report

His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, issued directives to intensify efforts and adopt world-class benchmarks to ensure Dubai continues to set the standard as the best city in the world across sectors.

“Today, Dubai leads the world in key competitiveness indicators. We want Dubai to be the best city in the world across all sectors. We want every official to redouble their efforts, set clear benchmarks, and ensure rapid, measurable progress towards this vision,” Shaikh Mohammad said.

He added: “People are at the core of our decisions, policies, and projects. We aim to make Dubai the best city for children and families, tourists and traders, and the elderly — a city where people live with dignity and where society flourishes through cooperation, compassion, and harmony.”

Later, in a post on his official X account, Shai-

kh Mohammad wrote: “Today I attended the Mohammad Bin Rashid Leaders Forum, a gathering of the 1,000 most prominent figures from Dubai's public and private sectors.

“I call them Dubai's team, and I presented a renewed vision for them: that Dubai will become the most beautiful and sophisticated city in the world — in its location, stature, spirit, culture, and urban development.”

Cost-reduction strategies

Aligning with his vision, Government entities in Dubai are working on cost-reduction strategies for education and housing.

Aisha Abdulla Miran, Director General of the Knowledge and Human Development Authority (KHDA) said the authority has focused on making education more affordable and accessible for families.

Omar Hamad BuShehab, Director General of the Dubai Land Department and Chairman of the Mohammad Bin Rashid Housing Establishment said that while rising living costs are a global concern, Dubai has practical plans to mitigate these challenges.

SEE ALSO P5

Watch out for robotaxis on the streets of Dubai

Trial runs with safety drivers are on

DUBAI
BY ASHWANI KUMAR
Chief Reporter

Don't be surprised to see driverless taxis on Dubai streets ahead of their commercial launch in the first quarter of 2026. Pilot tests are under way in select parts of the city, including Jumeirah, said Khaled Al Awadhi, Director of Transportation Systems at RTA's Public Transport Agency.

The developments follow the MoUs inked this year by RTA with global autonomous



vehicle companies Baidu (Apollo Go), Pony.ai, and WeRide to introduce such services in the city. Pilot tests have been held on closed and open roads in Dubai Silicon Oasis, with all three companies completing initial trials. Open-road testing was conducted following RTA permits.

Currently, as many as 60 vehicles are involved — 50 by Baidu and 10 by WeRide. Once commercial operations commence in early 2026, the robotaxis will operate across a wider area without safety drivers, as rules and regulations for autonomous vehicles are already in place.

SEE ALSO P4

ALFRED'S NEW LOOK: INSURANCE MASCOT GETS MAKEOVER

In the ever-changing landscape of brand storytelling, few icons in the UAE have earned as much recognition and affection as Alfred, the mascot of InsuranceMarket.ae. Long regarded as more than just a marketing symbol, Alfred has embodied trust, care, and the promise of making insurance accessible and approachable for all.

This week, Alfred returned to the public eye with a refreshed look that is designed to be softer, warmer, and more relatable. While the new design gives him what many are calling a “cuter” appearance, industry observers note that the essence of Alfred remains firmly intact. He continues to represent the same dependability and human touch that have made him a household name across the country.

Executives at InsuranceMarket.ae said the redesign goes beyond cosmetic change. It aims to deepen the emotional connection with policyholders and the wider community, reflecting the company's ongoing commitment to service, innovation, and simplicity.

With this evolution, Alfred further secures his place as one of the UAE's most recognisable brand companions, adapting to the times while holding fast to the values that built his legacy.